



This painting shows battleships in the Ten Years' War (1868–78), which was part of the long-running struggle for Cuba's independence from Spain.



KARL MARX (1818–83)

Karl Marx was a German philosopher, political economist, historian, political theorist, sociologist, and communist revolutionary, whose ideas played a significant role in the development of modern communism and socialism—theories collectively known as Marxism. His critique of capitalism, *Das Kapital*, remains influential today.

Prague, Prussia received Schleswig-Holstein, Hanover, Hesse-Kassel, Nassau, and Frankfurt, allowing it to organize the **North German Confederation**. The king of Prussia, **William I** (1797–1888) was at its helm, backed by Prime Minister **Otto von Bismarck** (see 1862). Austria also gave up control of the Venetia (Venice), allowing the region to be unified with Italy.

**WITH THE FALL IN 1868 OF THE TOKUGAWA SHOGUNATE** in Japan and the rise of the emperor Meiji Tenno (1852–1912), the island reversed its policy of isolationism and began a program of Westernization, with the aim of being able to stand up to the Western powers that were demanding access to Japan (see 1853). This period, known as the **Meiji Restoration**, was a time of long-lasting fundamental social reforms, such as the ending of feudalism, formation of a national army, and implementation of tax systems, with a constitutional government being convened by 1890. There was a boom in infrastructure modernization throughout this period, with the arrival of railroads and the telegraph.

In **Cuba**, discontent with the Spanish regime had been growing. When Queen Isabella II (1830–1904) was deposed by a military rebellion in Spain, Cubans seeking independence took the opportunity to launch a war against the Spanish rulers on their island. Led by Carlos Manuel de Céspedes, this uprising, known as **El Grito de Yara** (The Cry of Yara), resulted in The Ten Years' War (1868–78), a campaign of guerilla warfare that ended in failure for the Cuban rebels.

#### Meiji vase

A Japanese Satsuma cabinet vase from the Meiji period. Art was well supported by the Japanese government during this period.



In the same year, there was also an uprising against Spanish rule in Puerto Rico. The Lares uprising, or **El Grito de Lares**, was shortlived and, like the Cuban uprising, also ended in failure.

In **South Africa**, British control was spreading. Boer settlers had moved away from the Cape Colony, taking land from local tribes, including the neighboring Basutoland. Sotho leader **Moshoeshe I** (c. 1786–1870) asked Britain for help against further incursions into **Sotho territory**, and the result was that the kingdom was annexed to the British Crown in 1868, becoming a protectorate. On Moshoeshe's death in 1870, it was made part of the Cape Colony region without consulting the Sotho people.

“...REJOICE THAT I HAVE LIVED TO SEE THIS DAY, WHEN THE COLORED PEOPLE... HAVE EQUAL PRIVILEGES WITH THE MOST FAVORED.”

Thomas Garrett, American abolitionist, on the passing of the 15th Amendment



#### Grand opening

The opening of the Suez Canal, Port Said, Egypt. The project took a decade to complete but its impact on global trade was immediate.

**AS RECONSTRUCTION CONTINUED** in the war-torn southern US, Congress enacted an amendment to the Constitution—ratified by the states in February 1869—that extended the right to vote to all black men, whether they had been enslaved or not. The **Fifteenth Amendment** declared that “the rights of the citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of race, color, or previous condition of servitude”.

Meanwhile, westward expansion in the US continued to grow, aided by the arrival of railroads. By 1869, the **first transcontinental railroad** had been completed by the Central Pacific Railroad. The project was supported by government bonds. Part of the track was started from Sacramento, California, heading east and joining with existing lines in Promontory, Utah, on May 10, 1869. Much of the work on this stretch of railroad was done by more than 10,000 Chinese

immigrant laborers. The construction of this line allowed rapid coast-to-coast travel in the US, further facilitating western settlement.

Another feat of engineering also opened around the same time—the **Suez Canal** (see 1859). After a decade of construction, this canal linked the Mediterranean and Red seas, and provided a much quicker passage to the Indian Ocean.

In South Africa, **diamonds** had been discovered in the **Northern Cape province** in 1866, and soon a rush was on between the Boers, British, and native people to mine them. The British swiftly stepped in to annex the territory while **thousands of prospectors** arrived to try their luck.

**June 19** Emperor of Mexico, Maximilian I executed

**October 18** Transfer ceremony held after US buys Alaska territory from Russia

**October 18** Diamond fields discovered in South Africa

**August 18** Helium discovered by French astronomer Pierre Janssen (1824–1907)

**September 23** Japan's Meiji period of social and political reform (to 1912)

**September 23** Puerto Rico's El Grito de Lares, a bid for independence from Spanish rule, ends in failure

**September** Spain's Isabella II forced to flee during liberal uprising

**October 1** Rama V (1853–1910) takes Thai throne and ushers in era of reform

**October 10** Cuba starts Ten Years' War of independence against Spain

**February 3** 15th Amendment ratified, giving vote to freed slaves in US

**March 24** Titokowaru's War (New Zealand Land Wars) ends in Maori surrender

**May 4–10** Naval Battle of Hakodate in Japan between Imperial Japanese Navy and Tokugawa shogunate (Meiji restoration)

**May 10** Completion of Central Pacific Railroad in US

**November 17** Opening of Suez Canal